runaway success because of its ruggedness and capacity to overload the carrier so much so that it earned the moniker of ‘chota hathi’ (small elephant in Hindi) in India, where elephants are also associated with the strength to move large weights.

Ratan said the launch of the mini truck was the company’s effort to ‘differentiate itself by developing products that are designed to meet the needs of the vast and growing “lower segments of the pyramid”, in addition to the product range it sells today’. Besides being the progenitor of the Ace, he was actively involved at virtually each stage of its conceptualization, development and production. He gave the team ‘encouragement, guidance and support’ and took ‘personal interest in product styling, performance benchmarking, and product positioning’, concluded a Harvard Business School case study on the vehicle.

Charting Destiny

In 2005, Ratan said in an interview: ‘We want to expand into geographies where, as a group, we can have a meaningful presence … [and] where we are able to participate, as we have in India, in the development of that country.’

Around this time, Tata Motors successfully launched both commercial and passenger vehicles in Russia, Turkey and South Africa. Daewoo’s acquisition had given it a new opportunity to export heavy commercial vehicles. As Ratan said at the 2005 AGM, the new ‘Tata Daewoo Heavy Commercial Vehicle Company’ had started selling in ‘several overseas markets, complementing the company’s existing product range’. The success of the acquisition encouraged him to continue with this strategy. Soon, the company bought a 21 per cent stake in Hispano Carrocera SA, the embattled Spanish bus and coach maker. It expanded Tata Motors’ product range, bringing in ‘high-end buses and the related technology to address the luxury bus segment in various geographies’.

Ratan’s vision and aggressive push saw Tata Motors emerging as the ‘largest manufacturer of commercial vehicles and passenger cars in the country [it had 58.5 per cent and 15.5 per cent shares respectively], and the fifth largest medium and heavy commercial vehicle manufacturer globally’ in 2005.